



2025 Concert

Sunday July 20, 2.00pm
Nelson Centre of Musical Arts

Programme

John Rimmer
Cloud Fanfares

Igor Stravinsky
The Firebird Suite (1919 version)

- I - Introduction*
- II – The Firebird and its Dance*
- III – Variation of the Firebird*
- IV – The Princesses' Khovorod (Rondo)*
- V – Infernal Dance of King Koschei*
- VI – Lullaby*
- VII - Finale*

INTERVAL

Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky
Violin Concerto, Op.35

Soloist: Rachel Moxham

- I – Allegro moderato*
- II – Canzonetta: Andante*
- III – Finale: Allegro vivacissimo*

John Rimmer (1939 -)

Cloud Fanfares

Cloud Fanfares is one of ten fanfares for orchestra commissioned in 1990 by the Auckland Philharmonia Orchestra to celebrate its tenth anniversary. This celebration coincided also with the 150th anniversary of the signing of the Treaty of Waitangi and the opening of the Aotea Centre in Auckland.

More specifically Cloud Fanfares is a musical symbol of discovery. To the explorers of the Pacific Ocean, clouds were a confirmation that land was near. These 'Cloud' Fanfares thus celebrate the discovery of Pacific islands and in particular Aotearoa New Zealand.

Note copied from the SOUNZ website (<https://sounz.org.nz/works/20573>)

Igor Stravinsky (1882-1971)

The Firebird Suite (1919 version)

I - Introduction

II – The Firebird and its Dance

III – Variation of the Firebird

IV – The Princesses' Khovorad (Rondo)

V – Infernal Dance of King Koschei

VI – Lullaby

VII – Finale

Many Russian artists at the turn of the 20th century, faced with revolutionary turbulence at home, found refuge elsewhere in Europe - where Russian art and culture was in fashion. So it was that the impresario Sergei Diaghilev founded the Ballet Russes company in Paris in 1909 and sought to delight Parisians by commissioning a new ballet that quintessentially celebrated Russian folk culture.

The plot for *The Firebird* (*L'Oiseau de feu*) was devised by a group of artists led by ballerino Michael Fokine and draws on elements from multiple fairytales. Although Diaghilev and Fokine had established reputations at the time, Igor Stravinsky, the 27-year-old composer did not – and was only commissioned to write the score on account of multiple other composers being unavailable. It was a commission that would launch his career, something immediately appreciated by Diaghilev who commented, prior to the premiere “mark him well... he is a man on the eve of celebrity”.

Although based in the Russian romantic tradition of Nicolai Rimsky-Korsakov (Stravinsky's composition teacher) and drawing heavily on folk melodies, the colour and often irregular rhythms of *The Firebird* hint at the more radical ballets that Stravinsky would later compose for Ballet Russes – most prominently *The Rite of Spring*.

Stravinsky himself capitalised on the success of *The Firebird*, producing three revisions of the orchestral suite and, by his own words, going on to conduct a version of *The Firebird* “nearly a thousand times” – including in a series of 1961 concerts in New Zealand, with the NZSO.

The concert this afternoon features the 1919 version of the suite – the most frequently performed. Although less than half the length of the ballet, the full story, featuring the villainous King Koschei, heroic Prince Ivan, and the magical firebird, can still be traced through its seven movements.

We open in Koschei's enchanted garden, where Ivan and the firebird appear. Following a tussle, Ivan is gifted a magical feather by the firebird. Ivan then encounters 13 beautiful princesses held prisoner by Koschei. Ivan falls in love with the youngest and they share a dance. Suddenly, Koschei appears. Ivan is almost defeated by Koschei, when the firebird returns and enchants Koschei and his guards into an “infernal dance”. Exhausted by the dance, and lulled by the firebird's lullaby, Koschei falls asleep. Ivan kills Koschei and releases the princesses, and the ballet ends in triumphant celebration.

Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky (1840-1893)

Violin Concerto, Op.35

I – Allegro moderato

II – Canzonetta: Andante

III – Finale: Allegro vivacissimo

Tchaikovsky in 1878 was recovering from the trauma of a marriage that lasted only two months: an ill-conceived attempt to hide his homosexuality in a deeply intolerant society, to a woman he described in correspondence to his brother as “deeply repulsive”. Seeking escape he set on a trip outside of Russia, including several weeks staying on the shores of Lake Geneva with his friend (and ex-student), violinist Yosif Kotek. It was during this time that he composed the Violin Concerto at rapid pace.

Kotek was instrumental to the process of composition, trying out passages as soon as they were written. Yet ultimately Tchaikovsky offered the premiere instead to the Hungarian violinist Leopold Auer, seeking a high-profile soloist. Auer declined, regarding the solo part as unplayable. Kotek and Tchaikovsky’s friendship never recovered from the snub.

After a three-year search for a soloist, the concerto was ultimately premiered by Adolf Brodsky, a young Russian virtuoso. Critic Eduard Hanslick notoriously criticised the concerto, describing that it “stank to the ear”. Nonetheless it rapidly established itself as one of the great violin concerti, Auer later writing he “often deeply regretted” his refusal to play the premiere. Although at times fiery, the music’s lyricism and elegance offers little clue to the turbulence in Tchaikovsky’s life at the time.

Programme notes for The Firebird Suite and Tchaikovsky’s Violin Concerto written by Tom Wilkinson.

Our Soloist

Rachel Moxham

Rachel is a violinist based in Rotorua. She holds an Honours degree in classical violin performance from the University of Waikato, where she studied with Amalia Hall and Lara Hall. In her time as a musician, she has been a member of winning chamber music ensembles, played Violin 1 in Opus Orchestra and the NZSO National Youth Orchestra, and led St Matthew's Chamber Orchestra and the New Zealand Doctor's Orchestra as Concertmaster.

Rachel is also a new doctor, working as a first-year house officer in Rotorua Hospital, and hopes to become a generalist of some description (she is happy to be persuaded into most fields). After many years away from solo playing, she is thrilled to have the privilege of performing the mighty Tchaikovsky Violin Concerto with the New Zealand Doctors' Orchestra.

Our Conductor

Mark Hodgkinson

Mark Hodgkinson is a Christchurch-based free-lance conductor and music teacher. He has conducted the New Zealand Doctors' Orchestra on eight previous occasions, starting with our inaugural concert in 2012. We welcome him again as our conductor this year. Mark studied performance trumpet at the University of Canterbury and in Sweden, and played with the Auckland Philharmonia Orchestra for three years before returning to Christchurch. His conducting experience began with Christchurch School of Music ensembles and continued in Sweden with the Limhamns Brass Band. He gained further experience at the Aspen Music Festival and School in Colorado.

Mark has conducted the Canterbury Philharmonia since 1988. He has also conducted for Perkel Opera, Mercury Opera, Christchurch Operatic, Canterbury Music Theatre, Christchurch Youth Orchestra, South Island Youth Orchestra, Christchurch Symphony Orchestra, Nelson Symphony Orchestra, Canterbury Opera, Da Capo, Camerata Strings, Resonance, and the Christchurch Artist Doctors' Orchestra. He conducted Toi Toi Opera's inaugural production of *Suor Angelica* in February 2021. More recently he has conducted arrangements of *Stairway to Heaven* and *Viva La Vida* for St Andrew's College, with both performances receiving substantial views on YouTube channels. Forthcoming engagements include conducting Toi Toi Opera's season of Vaughan William's *Riders to the Sea* and the Christchurch School of Music's Alumni Orchestra as part of the School's 70th anniversary celebrations.

About the Orchestra

This is the 13th year that the New Zealand Doctors' Orchestra has met. Previous performances have been in Nelson, New Plymouth, Napier, Christchurch and Dunedin.

The members of the orchestra are doctors or medical students, with a small number of guest players. All members maintain a strong part-time interest in music, with many having very impressive musical CVs.

Each year we donate all proceeds from ticket sales. This year we are proud to donate all proceeds to **Nelson Tasman Hospice**.

Acknowledgements

We are very grateful for sponsorship from MAS. Sponsorship from the University of Otago (Division of Humanities Performing Arts Fund and the Medical School), and the University of Auckland (Faculty of Medicine and Health Sciences) has been used to subsidise costs for our student players.

We are also grateful to the Nelson Symphony Orchestra for the loan of equipment and instruments.

The Orchestra

Violin 1

Osman Ozturk
Justine Bradley
Allister Bush
Victoria Chanwai
Caitlyn Cunningham-Tisdall
Matthew Farrant
Emily Jin
Emily Joe
Juno Kim
Roy Knill
Victoria Lee
Jason Yan

Violin 2

Nicholas Pittar
Sally Langley
Catherine Lynch
Lynette Murdoch
Erika Sirisomboonwong
Sonja Sparrow
Iain Ward
Louise Webster
Daniel Wong
Elaine Wong

Viola

Anthony Doyle
Nicola Austin
Rebecca Benny
Stephanie Cox
Alexandra Hurrell
Fiona McPherson
Alex Puttick
Hugh Townend

Cello

Dominic Monaghan
James Donaldson⁺
Jane MacDonald
Wendy Ni
Sue Stubbs
Paul Teoh
Clare Woodward

Double bass

Jacob Bond
Kate Stephens
Tim Wilkinson

Flute

Karin Lamb
Malcolm Carmichael
Claudia Hays

Oboe

Ruth Moore
Kate Shoebridge
Nicola van Gelder-Horgan

Cor Anglais

Jonathan Christiansen

Clarinet

Jonathan Christiansen
Lorna Pairman
Gautam Pathumanithy

Bassoon

Martin Gardner
Matthew Payne
James Smythe

Horn

Rhona Sommerville
Hugh Goodman
Scott Zhou
John Rimmer⁺

Trumpet

Tom Wilkinson
Nicholas Anticich
Lucy Page-Dalton

Trombone

Mark Barnes
Jon Dallimore
Kevin Roberts

Tuba

Dylan Blomquist

Timpani

Micah Yang

Percussion

Mattie Lang⁺
Robin Le Couteur⁺
Kate Redgrove⁺

Piano

Jasmine Jiang

Harp

Vanessa Souter

⁺= guest player